

4/ Pragmatic Fairness: Customary Rules of Deliberation

It's just very pragmatic. You put twelve pretty smart people in a windowless room in [some city] for two days and you expect them to remain sane. They're pretty professional people, so they do their best. They have very different tastes so there's a lot of potential for conflict. They stay cool-headed and they have to make these heroic efforts to agree across big disciplinary differences on what constitutes a good proposal . . . We spend so much time on it and . . . there's so many people focusing at once on this proposal . . . This year particularly, there was a lot of movement: You had a lot of situations where something was ranked relatively high [prior to the meeting and] weaknesses were discussed and people in favor were convinced [not to fund]. And conversely, something [ranked] quite low, [but] the more you talked about it, the more it looked like you should give it a chance, that it had some promise . . . It would be sort of self-congratulatory to say that cream rises to the top and that we picked exactly the right set. I don't think that happened. But I think we chose on average the better proposals.

Economist

Academic excellence? I know it when I see it . . . If I didn't, I couldn't honestly do all of the selecting and advising I do. I would even go farther and say I'm extremely confident in my own judgment and con-

tradition does not affect me very much . . . Everything is relative in some ways, but I do believe there are real qualities, which I'm identifying, which are pretty related . . . What rises to the top is cream, but I am not convinced that all the cream makes it. I do worry about, for example, what happens to people who for one reason or another don't make it to the very best possible graduate program . . . My sense is that in every case you get a high degree of agreement . . . people will suppress a very strong outlying opinion, or perhaps briefly and mildly express it, in order to make the process work.

Historian

Almost without exception, the panelists I talked with consider their deliberations fair and their panel able to identify the top proposals.¹ Like the economist quoted earlier, the evaluators do not believe that their panel did a perfect job, but they do maintain that they identified the best proposals “on average.” They agree that meritocracy guides the process of selection and that unfettered market mechanisms generally determine the outcome of the competition. Some qualify their views by referring to the “role of chance and passion” in the process, and some acknowledge that “mistakes are made.” Overall, however, they are confident that panels succeed in identifying high-quality proposals, and that peer review “works” as a mechanism for quality control. As one art historian put it, “I think on the whole we do a pretty good job of identifying, not individually but collectively, . . . quality research that could be considered ‘the cream.’” This belief resonates with their broader investment in a “culture of academic excellence” that precludes panelists from framing the outcome of the deliberations as an expression of cronyism. In fact, a tradition of not indulging in expressions of self-interest is one of the reasons that panelists say they enjoy serving on panels (“officiating as priest” as one of them puts it). “I’m really impressed,” a historian says, referring to his experience on a panel, “when people

can step outside of their own interests and out of their own interest groups and look at something from another perspective.” A somewhat frequent outcome of group deliberation is a feeling of satisfaction that the group has shared an appreciation of good work and has come to a consensus regarding the evaluations.

Indeed, such heartfelt and personal aspects of academic life feature prominently in panelists’ talk about their experience as evaluators. They enjoy deeply both seeing a brilliant mind at work and reading a perfectly crafted proposal. As suggested in Chapter 2, their commitment to the distinctive pleasures and virtues of academic life cannot be overestimated as a factor that shapes how they think about their responsibilities as panel members. The point here is that although panelists’ beliefs in academic excellence and in the fairness of the funding process do not come “naturally,” neither do they appear to be expressions of false consciousness or ritualized covers for self-interest.² Like all social actors, these academics rely on various, and sometimes inconsistent or contradictory, frames to give meaning to their actions.

In this chapter, I explore the social conditions that lead panelists to understand their choices as fair and legitimate. This is quite different from determining whether the process of peer review itself is fair. There is already a large literature on that question.³ Typically, such studies have focused on those values and norms of the scientific institution that support fairness in evaluation by ensuring that no one is excluded from scientific debates due to purely subjective social factors.⁴ In contrast, my concern is with the frameworks or meaning systems—the rules of the game—that panelists use to understand their actions and the environment in which they are operating.⁵ Although the scholars I interviewed are almost unanimous in their belief that “the process works,” they are not always sure how it works. A panel chair, for instance, stressing that “the consensus candidates were [agreed on] at a high level,” concludes, “I think the process

works very well,” but then adds, “It’s just hard to articulate what it is.” This chapter aims to clarify the complicated dynamics of group evaluation.

Producing Legitimacy and Belief through Customary Rules

Max Weber and Emile Durkheim, two of the founding fathers of the field of sociology, each wrote about the production of belief. Weber identified various forms of legitimacy and suggested that the production of rational-legal legitimacy requires belief in the use of impersonal, abstract, and consistent rules.⁶ This in turn requires the bracketing of individual interest. Durkheim, in his writings about the production of religious feelings and the mechanisms by which people come to invest in the sacred, maintained that the sacred is defined by its separation from the sphere of the profane through the use of rituals—rule-bound processes.⁷ Weber’s and Durkheim’s insights are directly relevant to the actions of panel members. Funding organizations provide evaluators with formal rules. These institutional mandates constrain the kinds of arguments that panelists make by affecting the likelihood that specific criteria—whether a proposal is excessively or insufficiently humanistic, comparative, policy-oriented, and so on—will be invoked against or in favor of a proposal. Evaluators do sometimes refer to specific guidelines to bolster their arguments, or to resolve disagreements. But, as noted in Chapter 2, program officers give panelists full sovereignty and rarely enforce the mandates. A sociologist recalls that a proposal that did not have the focus specified by the competition, but which everyone judged to be excellent, was funded. Another sociologist, downplaying the influence of the formal guidelines, comments, “I doubt that most people read them all that carefully.”

As I explain in more detail later in this chapter, the rules that pan-

elists do pay careful attention to, the ones that lead them to assign great legitimacy to the outcome of their deliberations, are informal. I describe these rules as “customary” because they are not formally spelled out and are instead created and learned by panelists during their immersion in collective work.⁸ Some of these rules are meant to standardize procedures, and they promote the bracketing of personal interest (for example, norms for abstaining from decisions involving one’s students). Others, such as deferring to expertise, operate as ritual and are used to separate the “sacred” (excellence) from the “impure” (self-interest, idiosyncratic preferences, narrowness, disciplinary parochialism, and so on). As one panelist explains, replying to a question about how he thought about his experience, “I think it has to do with almost sacred value, with value that transcends institutions, individuals, networks, and things like that. What you’re trying to achieve is something that goes beyond individual interest and perspective.”

In a general sense, all the informal rules that guide deliberations are deeply familiar to panelists. In the process of doing their jobs as academics, panel members become accustomed to making judgments; they evaluate students’ and colleagues’ performance, manuscripts for publication, and tenure cases. What distinguishes the assessments that academics perform on grant and fellowship panels from those that occur in departmental evaluations is context. As we saw in Chapter 2, panelists are not engaged in a sustained relationship with one another; nor do they have to share the lives of awardees, as they do with newly hired colleagues or graduate students who have been admitted to their department. As a consequence of the limited personal stake in the outcome and of the lack of time, they are not likely to mobilize their networks to gather information on the personal qualities of the candidate, as they might do (in some instances) when serving on recruitment committees.⁹ At the same time, since universalism is essential to the legitimacy of the

process, panelists are expected to work hard to keep their personal connections and idiosyncratic preferences from affecting their funding decisions. But these rules are not always abided by and they remain ideals shaping the understanding of how panelists believe a successful panel should conduct itself. There are obvious tensions between, for instance, the ideal of methodological pluralism and the commitment that panelists have to their own disciplinary evaluative culture.

This chapter looks closely at how panelists struggle to identify and agree on criteria for academic excellence. The analysis reveals that making judgments about excellence is a deeply interactional and emotional undertaking, rather than a strictly cognitive one.

What Makes a Good Panelist

The legitimacy of panels rests mainly on impersonal rules (what Weber described as “rational-legal” grounds), but elements associated with traditional authority, where obedience is due to the person who occupies the position of authority, are present as well.¹⁰ The authority of panelists is determined by their formal technical training (as PhD holders) and by their reputation, and is thus attached directly to their person. This means that although in principle all panelists have the same degree of legitimacy, their individual credibility and relative authority within panels are determined in important ways by their behavior. With this in mind, I asked panelists, program officers, and panel chairs to describe what in their view makes a panelist “good” or “bad.” I also questioned them concerning the person who impressed them most and least on their respective panels, and how they perceived themselves to be similar to or different from other panelists.¹¹

The interviewees often expressed enthusiasm when describing “good” colleagues, confirming that sheer pleasure and intellectual

enjoyment motivate academics to add to their already considerable workload by serving on funding panels. The wonderment of discovering new domains of knowledge by interacting with smart colleagues is often palpable as respondents discuss their experiences on panels. At the same time, their answers frequently emphasize their colleagues' interpersonal skills and fundamental character traits. Program officers, in particular, uniformly stress the importance of "collegiality" when describing what they look for in a panelist and acknowledge that they take special care to select personable or like-minded participants. As the following list of traits or behaviors needed to qualify as a "good panelist" suggests, the quality of a panelist is defined not only in cognitive terms, but also in terms of "presentation of self," as well as moral and emotional characteristics.¹²

Show up fully prepared and ready to discuss the proposals. Demonstrating a strong sense of responsibility and work ethic is clearly key to being a good panelist. A political scientist describes the best evaluator on his panel as a historian "who always had very thoughtful commentary on the proposals. He had clearly engaged the proposals themselves; he did not get swept away by fluff or anything." A sociologist explicitly states that she assigns the most weight to the opinions of co-panelists who are the best prepared and best informed. Preparedness and command of details enhance credibility because they improve a panelist's ability to think on his feet when trying to convince other evaluators.

Demonstrate intellectual breadth and expertise. A good panelist demonstrates a command of large literatures within her field, has passive knowledge of several areas beyond her field, and is able to assess quickly the strengths and weaknesses of proposals in all these areas. One panelist recalls two notable colleagues: "I remember being really impressed by the amount that she [an architectural historian] knew.

When she was an expert about something, she was completely convincing about it. I remember being perhaps even more impressed with the American historian's range of knowledge . . . [He] kept talking about varying courses that he taught in which he had become expert on x, y, and z, and it seemed an enormously broad range. He's one of these people who read very widely and retained everything that he read and I was tremendously delighted by that; he was very helpful."

Be succinct. Panelists' work is conducted at a fast pace, because they generally have to accomplish a great deal in a very limited amount of time. It is crucial that members not waste everyone's time by talking too much or too slowly, making unnecessary remarks, or providing too much detailed information. A humanist remembers being put off by a panel member who "would kind of go off on tangents that were irrelevant and tell sort of anecdotes, and we had an agenda [a pile of proposals to go through]." A historian picks as the worst panelist an anthropologist who "talked way too much about proposals that he hadn't read, [and] had to make his views known about everything." A political scientist offers a similar indictment of this same panelist: "This guy was just so full of himself. For me, I sort of lost my tolerance when at the end [the chair] keeps saying 'let's move along,' and he keeps on name dropping on these proposals." Panelists who are not succinct lose credibility; "being smart" also means knowing how to use one's time effectively in a group.

Speak across disciplinary boundaries. Being able to articulate one's point of view to others outside one's field is essential. An English professor equates this with "smarts." She feels that her co-panelists all exhibited this trait. "Each of the people in the panel made remarks at different points that taught me something that was new and that was not just a person's opinion about a proposal. I felt like I

was in a classroom learning something important about history or about music or whatever it might be.” Of course, being accessible to nonexperts is a more valued asset for those serving on multidisciplinary, as opposed to unidisciplinary, panels.

Respect other people’s expertise and sentiments. An appreciation of others’ views translates into a willingness to listen and to be convinced by another person’s assessment. A historian’s explanation for why he felt closest to two women co-panelists sums up the importance of respect among panel members:

I liked the way they interacted with other people on the panel, always respectful. Their interpersonal skills, I felt comfortable with them . . . I felt that I could say what I wanted to say and it would be heard respectfully. I thought that they had read the proposals very carefully. I guess I felt sometimes that the other guy’s readings did not seem to be as detailed, although that may have not been the case. But in addition to that, the women I thought also commanded a kind of intellectual respect.

Conversely, the most negative comments made about other panelists often concern how they interact with others, handle differences of opinion, and contribute to shared goals. Although expressing differences of opinion is deemed acceptable, avoiding open confrontation is viewed as essential. Indeed, a humanist describes a co-panelist as follows: “[He] could be a little . . . bit contentious and confrontational in ways that seemed to be a little unnecessary. [He] made pronouncements, expressing his contempt for this or that.” Another panelist, this same humanist recalls, “had a kind of flaky irreverence that I think grated on us a bit . . . He made any number of odd jokes of borderline sensitivity and appropriateness.” Undoubtedly, the value assigned to interpersonal sensitivity is to some extent his-

torically specific: it is more crucial in an environment characterized by uncertainty, where conflict avoidance, along with eschewing comments that might offend specific constituencies (defined in sexual, gender, racial, ethnic, religious, class, or national terms), may be the safest strategy. A more aggressive masculine style may have been more acceptable a generation ago, when higher education was more homogeneous or “clubby” than it is now.¹³

Preparedness, expertise, succinctness, intellectual depth and multidisciplinary breadth, respectfulness, and sensitivity to others: these traits and skills all go into the equation that defines a good panelist and establishes an individual’s credibility. The ideal personality for a panelist is captured by a sociologist as he reviews the traits he feels made his panel’s chair superlative: “[He has] a very good sense of [the field], [is] smooth, agreeable, charming, and very much blessed with a sense of reality, up on the literature, very well informed . . . he listened, [was] brisk, efficient, everything a chairman could be.” Yet this description is very much at odds with that presented in most of the literature on peer review. Most studies emphasize exclusively cognitive factors and the exercise of power and downplay the role of emotion and interpersonal signaling (about one’s morality, for instance).¹⁴ The misalignment between the traits and behaviors that panelists single out and those that researchers have focused on hints at the importance of considering evaluation as an emotional process, as opposed to the more typical approach of focusing on cognition and final outcomes. These traits also suggest that the credibility of panelists seems to inhere both in their person and in their disciplines and institutions.

The Central Rules of Deliberation

Panel deliberations follow principles analogous to those that some theorists prescribe for deliberative democracy.¹⁵ The standard of rec-

iprocity applies, as does an overall orientation toward producing consensual decisions and realizing the common good. Moreover, panelists are expected to convince one another with the force of reason. The requirement that panels make specific, informed decisions necessitates that each participant be given full liberty to express her opinion without any reprisal, and that each be provided opportunity for full and equal voice. The meeting is deliberative to the extent that this full, equal, and free exchange of opinion is sustained. Although the panels are conducted in secrecy, evaluators are accountable to the funding organization, as well as morally accountable to the wider academic community.

There are limitations on these ideal conditions of equality, however. Panel members vary in age, race, and gender, and they represent institutions of uneven prestige (characteristics discussed in more detail later). More importantly, each of the panelists also claims expertise on a specific subset of topics covered by the proposals.¹⁶ Thus their opinion is given more or less weight depending on the subject of discussion.

Deferring to expertise and observing disciplinary sovereignty. For many proposals, alternative framings are possible. Is a proposal well-written or glib? Is it broad and daring or dilettantish? Is it current or trendy? Painstakingly focused or disappointingly obscure? Panelists formulate interpretive frames and attempt to convince one another that theirs is most apt. It is this context that gives rise to “deferring to expertise,” a foundational rule for sustaining collective belief in the fairness of peer review. When panelists want to advocate a position regarding a proposal, they invest energy in staking their rightful claim to evaluate it based on their past research or teaching. That is, they mark their territory.¹⁷ In other cases, they draw on previously established proofs of competence; in still others, they remain silent. A historian uses himself as an example as he explains how a panelist might openly claim authority. During a discussion of a proposal on

modernity and the media in the United States, he mentioned to the group that he had done work on the period covered by the proposal, and that for this reason he was particularly well positioned to assess its contribution. “I think I had expert advice here, and I think that’s why she got [the funding], because I had expert advice,” he concludes.

Panelists defer to the expertise of others because the situation requires that they take positions on topics about which they know very little. An anthropologist says: “Philosophy, I didn’t feel at all as if I were competent to evaluate those proposals. [I don’t mention this] to say this is good or this is not good; I just did not know what was up with them. And in those cases, I always deferred to the people who did have some kind of expertise in that field.”

Hearing the opinions of experts is also essential when panelists are comparing proposals that speak to a wide range of unfamiliar topics. An English professor who “tended to give high marks to some proposals [where] I had no education about the field” counts on the corrective influence of more knowledgeable panelists. While he found the proposed work simply “exciting,” “some other panelist would be able to say very quickly, ‘This is not original work, you know.’ There’d be no way for me to know that in advance.” Similarly, a historian notes that a proposal “looks good until somebody says there’s a whole literature that you cannot reasonably be expected to know.” Particularly when listening to someone who “comes in extremely expert and careful and [is] a person I respect a lot,” this historian finds it prudent to defer. “[If this expert] says, ‘. . . this is really a fairly banal proposal,’ then I just sort of say that must be true.”

The most common form of deference involves what I call respecting disciplinary sovereignty. Panelists’ opinions generally are given more weight according to how closely the proposal overlaps “their” field. Another historian spells out this culture of disciplinary deference:

For a couple of proposals, I had to “explicate” a research strategy that wasn’t fully explained. [My historical expertise] on the whole had a lot of weight. Sometimes I almost felt uncomfortable about the deference that was given to my responses as a historian . . . There was a lot of credibility given to the way I responded to historical questions in particular. And I, of course, returned the deference to people in the other fields.

This willingness to recognize and defer to expertise can have drawbacks. An English professor’s description of her tentative (and failed) attempt to save a proposal from being labeled “dilettantish” illustrates the way in which deference can limit rather than promote discussion:

I work in twentieth century, but I’m not an expert in post-war, post-modern literature [the applicant’s field]. I think I know enough. I didn’t find [the proposal] dilettantish. So I was interested that so many people did, and I was sort of willing to defer. I [should have] pushed it a little further, even just to sort of clarify: Why is it dilettantish in this area? How much of this really is disciplinary intimidation? Are you willing to go to bat for this person? I would, if I think I knew a little bit more about the field . . . I think they thought there was too much theory, that there was an element of sort of name dropping, where I wondered whether a lot of this was a kind of inexperienced way of indicating what the critical literature might be . . . I just didn’t know enough to counter. If there was just another voice that was a little more enthusiastic, I would have, could have.

Maintaining collegiality. In combination, the rules of deference to expertise and respect of disciplinary sovereignty lead to a third important customary rule: collegiality. Panelists are expected to adopt a

consistently respectful tone toward one another, and not only as a nod to a long-gone era when academia was the private domain of honorable men of independent means. Collegiality has a concrete effect on panel discussions and their outcome; it is the oil that keeps the wheels of deliberation turning when panelists otherwise might not be willing to accommodate one another. Even if it at times limits the extent to which panelists engage in vigorous discussion as they compare proposals, collegiality is considered indicative of a “well-functioning” panel. A panel is described as “good” when panelists listen carefully to and are influenced by one another. This kind of respectful interaction diffuses the potential for frictions and tensions that could hinder decision making, and helps create an amicable environment. Indeed, many panelists mention being surprised at how friendly panels are, given the level of conflict that is customary in their respective departments. “I thought we were all listening to each other,” a person who served on a women’s studies panel says, adding, “[I] felt respected when I was speaking to something in my field.”

Alliances, Strategic Voting, and Horse-Trading

Beneath the panelists’ acceptance of the deliberation process as fair lies a second belief: that consistent and universalistic standards of evaluation are applied, which means that without regard to inessential differences, all proposals have an equal chance of being funded.¹⁸ This belief constrains how panelists think about alliance formation, strategic voting, and horse-trading. Although these activities potentially skew deliberations, panelists frame them as compatible with universalism and the “natural” rising of the cream.

Alliances. Many interviewees report aligning themselves with different panelists at different times, and noticing that others seem to do the same. They did not witness strong alliances among their

fellow panelists, perhaps because respondents' describe legitimate panel interactions as being among independent actors who act on a case-by-case basis. When probed further, however, most panelists reveal clear personal, intellectual, or theoretical affinities. For instance, a historian confesses feeling close to an English professor because

she clearly had a good deal of critical and literary theory in her background. So that to some extent she and I over the years would have been reading similar work, and we happen to be sympathetic towards it. [She is] also concerned with social significance, concerned with the voices of the other, evaluating proposals on questions of originality . . . [This is important] because if you believe in liberal education and you believe that education has a role in the formation of the citizen, then it seems to me you have to pay some attention to the plurality of what constitutes citizenship.

These elective personal qua intellectual affinities are not conceptualized as corrupting or illegitimate.¹⁹ From panelists' perspective, their task requires that they assess proposals using the more or less diverse intellectual tools they have at their disposal; these generally converge with those of at least some of their co-panelists. Thus particularism is to some extent unavoidable: the value assigned to proposals as cultural products depends largely on their embeddedness in the context of evaluation. That is, value is defined in reference to the other proposals under consideration, and by personal affinities and differences among reviewers.²⁰

Strategic voting and horse-trading. Similarly, strategic voting and horse-trading are, if not unavoidable, at least very common during deliberations, despite the centrality that panelists accord to universalism in interpreting the group of proposals as a whole. Strategic

voting refers to the practice of giving a lower rank that would otherwise be justified to some proposals (“low-balling”) in order to increase the likelihood that other proposals will win. It may also mean boosting the ranking of a mediocre or controversial proposal to improve its chances for funding. Horse-trading means enabling the realization of other panelists’ objectives in the hope that they will reciprocate. Some construe this as non-meritocratic, because the horses being traded are not necessarily equivalent, and one of them may “win” because of “politics” as opposed to intrinsic strength.

Many panelists, however, acknowledge strategic voting as normal, to the extent that they admit explicitly calibrating their own votes in anticipation of those of the other evaluators. An English professor, for instance, recalls ranking a feminist theorist’s proposal highly

partly because I knew that the other panelists would be put off by her style and I knew that I would want to argue very strongly in her favor . . . I’ve read her other work and I really admire it. She does something very close to what I aspire to do . . . Her style is very informal and very mannered, it’s not standard academic prose by any means . . . I just thought her style would be so annoying that people wouldn’t be able to see past it to the value of what she was doing. The other reason is, she takes psychoanalysis very seriously, and psychoanalysis is beloved only by a small remnant of literary critics. I figured that would probably turn some people away.

This professor describes her voting in strategic terms, but it is entirely legitimate for panelists to rank a proposal highly when they believe its quality justifies such a score. In every case, a vote aims to support a proposal or prevent its funding. It is strategic when it is guided primarily by a desire to facilitate or hinder the funding of another proposal, or to influence other panelists. The opposite of stra-

tegic voting is taking into consideration only the proposal itself, not the context of evaluation. While some panelists take pride in aiming for this goal, abstracting proposals from the context of evaluation is a social anomaly, and it is not easily or often achieved.

If strategically assigning a high rank to a proposal (“high-balling”) is considered permissible, low-balling is not, because it unfairly penalizes better proposals. In fact, low-balling is the only form of strategic voting that panelists describe as illegitimate. A historian, who suspected a philosopher of deliberately assigning low ranks, explains the problem:

I was a little bit concerned about [this guy’s] rankings because he gave a lot of “threes.” The problem with “threes” is they pretty much end a proposal. My sense in reading the instructions that we received is that all of the proposals had already gone through pre-screening and between fifty and sixty percent had already been eliminated, so that this was really the kind of *crème de la crème* . . . I can’t impute intention, but the effect was three simply meant the end of a proposal. At a certain point I guess I began to feel . . . “Is this a sort of political [that is, strategic] evaluation?”

Strategic voting and horse-trading are particularly crucial at the end of panel deliberations, when panelists are parceling out the last available fellowships, choosing among proposals that each are flawed, but differently so, and thus are not easily made commensurate. This eleventh-hour context forces panelists to engage in calculation and quid pro quo to a degree that may have been unnecessary or unthinkable at an earlier point. (The influence of timing on proposal evaluation is discussed at greater length later in this chapter.) A historian explains that “one of the reasons I honestly don’t mind making compromises is because [in the final stages, when] you’re dancing through all these [deals], you realize your [own] judgment, to say

the least, isn't perfect." An English professor reflects on her decision making in the final stages of deliberations this way:

What I decided about two-thirds of the way through the meeting is that there was one file I was going to go to the mat for around these issues [of applied knowledge]. I decided it was going to require me to figure out what I'd have to lose in order to get this one . . . I think that the process of these committee meetings is about negotiations. And at the end of the day, it seems to me one may need to think about these files in terms of categories . . . you kind of [have] to figure out which of these files in these particular categories is going to be the one that I can win. People aren't going to want to concede everything; everybody has their thing they want to win. And so if I'm going to try to win on these two fronts, I'm going to have to put my weight behind the strongest one and kind of lose the others.

Horse-trading is described here as part of the ordinary order of things once the consensus proposals have been funded. A historian provides a very similar view, while also stressing the importance of negotiation. "There was one [proposal] that I didn't like and argued against a couple times earlier in the day. At one point I realized that the other four people liked that and so I said 'Look, I'm probably wrong. I still don't like it but I'm probably wrong, so let's put it on the list.' And I think to some degree, just politically, that gave me some credibility when I wanted something else . . . because I showed good will."

The dynamics of ranking are such that many judgments are relational and conjectural, and it is in this context that panelists come to think strategically about what they can realistically accomplish. This is evidenced in the comments of another historian, as he explains why he deliberately chose not to veto a project he opposed:

I said to myself, “You win some, you lose some.” . . . One of the reasons I pulled back from vetoing is because we were quite sure that not all of the fellowships would be accepted, and that there would be an alternative source of funding. We were quite convinced that a person who I supported and ended up on the wait list would nevertheless be funded. And that trade-off ultimately made it seem acceptable.

In the end, panelists seem to support a pragmatic understanding of evaluation—one that is at odds with the ideals of using consistent standards and of ignoring proposals’ contexts to consider only their intrinsic qualities. Panelists seem acutely aware that scholarly quality is relationally defined within the universe of the group of proposals being evaluated. Which one is used as point of reference shifts throughout the deliberation. Across all disciplines, contextual ranking is central to the art of evaluation.

Bracketing Self-Interest and Personal Ties

The influence of self-interest and personal ties on the outcome of deliberations is viewed as entirely illegitimate in a panel review. This is consistent with Weber’s view on the production of rational legitimacy, which requires the application of impersonal and consistent rules. When I asked a panel chair how panelists would likely react to a member saying, “This is a student of a close colleague of mine and I’d love to see his work funded,” she replied,

It’s just not a consideration. It can’t be a consideration. You probably noticed that the panel rejected quite roundly a student of [a panelist], who described him as the best student he’d had in twenty-five years . . . Nobody thought about that. There are other types of biases that other people bring to the meetings, but they

tend to be well camouflaged . . . I hear criticisms from colleagues [such as] “Oh man, you’re just funding Chicago anthropology, it’s because you have all these Chicago anthropologists on your panel.” . . . And what I can tell you is that in my experience it looks the opposite. The more specialists you have on the Middle East, the fewer Middle East proposals are going to get through. Because people tend to be really tough on their discipline, to the point where they’re too tough and we have to think of ways to make them mellow to get them to say yes.

Taking perhaps an idiosyncratic stance, this panel chair also notes that the funding program tries to minimize the presence of panelists from Ivy League universities because of the large number of graduate students from such institutions who apply:

[We]’re looking for people who are not gatekeepers . . . I’m not sure how formal the policy is, but you did notice there was nobody from Harvard, Yale, Princeton, Chicago . . . And we definitely do not include people from those institutions [that produce] large numbers of area studies types of applications. No Michigan, no Berkeley. It’s almost an unwritten rule that we’re looking for people who . . . are not connected to the networks. We look for people who will decide applications on the basis of their intellectual merits, and not on who did it, where they’re coming from.

Thus, following Durkheim, self-interest can be understood as the “impure” juxtaposed against the sacrality of academic excellence, which is defined through the rituals panels follow to insure that there is no corruption. The formal rules of funding agencies clearly delineate the obligation to abstain when the work of close colleagues, friends, and direct advisees is being discussed. Although there is no

explicit requirement to do so, some panelists also volunteer information on indirect or informal ties (“this student’s mentor is a close collaborator of mine” or “I know this applicant’s adviser very well and trust her letter”). These disclosures are not offered systematically, perhaps because such ties are not uncommon. Given the degree of specialization in American academia, panelists are likely to know personally or by reputation most of the scholars whose areas closely overlap with their own, especially if they are very active in research circles, as are most evaluators.

Still, panelists’ awareness of the importance of limiting the “corrupting impact” of personal relationships makes disclosing informal ties common enough to be a customary rule. A historian’s reply to my asking him to describe his favorite proposal is illustrative: “That’s a little bit difficult because to be completely honest about it, the one that I liked the most was by a student who quoted me at length. I recused myself. I didn’t enter the discussion on that. She’s not literally my student. She did some independent work with me.” A sociologist, too, says she chose to remain silent when a former colleague’s work, which she does not appreciate, was discussed.

Both these scholars were pleased when the decision the panels reached in each case endorsed their own viewpoints. In contrast, all of the panelists I interviewed who had written letters for applicants (and who therefore excused themselves from the deliberations) were upset when these proposals were not funded. Such decisions, they said, made them feel awkward, as if their fellow evaluators are giving them a vote of no confidence. They said they abstained from asking the other panelists for an account of the deliberations, and the other panelists did not volunteer such information. Interestingly, the “slighted” parties seemed to expect such a breach of confidentiality, despite their commitment to universalism, and were disappointed when details were not forthcoming.

Because scholarly expertise is superposed onto the social networks

of those who produce the knowledge, it is impossible to eliminate the effect of interpersonal relationships, including clientelism, on the evaluation process. Nevertheless, discussions proceed as though panelists were free of these influences. Their individual preferences are usually construed in universalistic terms, despite the particularistic aspects introduced by real-world considerations. Evaluations of proposals are framed at least in part by what panelists believe are important topics, judgments that are tied to their personal view of the appropriate directions for a particular field. They are also shaped by letters of support that are more or less trusted, with the level of trust reflecting network connections.²¹ Furthermore, as we will now see, some panelists view idiosyncratic preferences as an acceptable component of evaluations.

Beyond Idiosyncratic Taste and Self-Reproduction

Rational legitimacy, Weber reminds us, comes from applying impersonal and consistent rules. Thus by trying to bracket their idiosyncratic tastes, panel members help sustain a collective belief in the deliberations' fairness. An English professor advocates distinguishing between one's personal preferences and criteria of competence, and privileging the latter when the two are in conflict. Referring to "a completely chaotic proposal," he comments:

The art historian and I both liked the kind of effervescence of the thing and thought it was probably worth thinking about, but I think others felt he was just too chaotic. What I found with these things, you need to use two sets of criteria. One is . . . your best professional judgment in as neutral a way as you can manage it, independent of your taste. And the other one is allowing for your tastes, if they don't get in the way of each other. I think one should always give up the personal one, if the arguments of other people seem sound, and not give up the other one.

In subordinating personal preferences to more neutral standards, this scholar protects the legitimacy of the process, but he also recognizes the role of individual subjectivities in evaluation. Similarly, a political scientist establishes a clear distinction between evaluating the choice of topic, which is not “objective,” and the quality of the proposal, which is “amenable to the canons of academic excellence.” A different panelist dismisses a colleague’s assessments, noting, “He seemed to value some proposals for very odd reasons that were more like personal taste than any kind of other criteria.”

Panelists’ concern over the influence of idiosyncratic tastes is tied to a desire to aim for the most universalistic standard possible. A historian of China makes this point when she states that she works hard to be a good panelist because

some would just say “Well, I don’t like this kind of thing, I don’t like that kind of thing.” . . . Professions are only a set of codes and standards, so if everything is going to be completely spontaneous and just according to your own whims, there isn’t going to be a profession. Plus, I just think the people out here submitting proposals to us should be able to understand what they’re aiming for.

Likewise, an economist values attempts to bracket “subjectivity” and instead make “objective” evaluations as often as possible. He praises another panelist because “he had the whole game in mind. I mean he was viewing the whole set of proposals and trying to be consistent.” An art historian is even more explicitly opposed to the use of idiosyncratic preferences in evaluation:

Everyone brings their own baggage. Certain people would say, “Well, I think this should be funded in part because it’s something that interests me, because it relates to my research, because it’s something I would like to see published, because it deals with the period prior to the period I’m [working on] . . . and that says a

great deal. One has to remain open to a degree and not get quite so personal. So I was struck often about how personal people did get.

These panelists' concerns are somewhat exceptional, however. Most reviewers uphold the legitimacy of the process by seamlessly folding their idiosyncratic preferences and tastes into the formal criteria of evaluation. So, for example, they tend to define originality in ways that are in line with the type of originality that their own work exhibits.²² As one interviewee acknowledges, evaluators tend to like what speaks to their own interests: "I see scholarly excellence and excitement in this one project on food, possibly because I see resonance with my own life, my own interests, who I am, and other people clearly don't. And that's always a bit of a problem, that excellence is in some ways . . . what looks most like you."

During interviews, multiple examples of how panelists' idiosyncratic interests shape their votes emerged. A panelist who loves modern dance confesses (without flinching), "The one on dance [I liked a lot]; I'm an avid dance person . . . in terms of studying dance, the history of dance and vernacular dance in particular. So I found that one really interesting, very good." Similarly, an anthropologist explains her support for a proposal on songbirds by noting that she had just come back from Tucson, where she had been charmed by songbirds. An English scholar supports a proposal on the body, tying her interest to the fact that she was an elite tennis player in high school. A historian doing cross-cultural, comparative work explicitly states that he favors proposals with a similar emphasis. Another historian doing research on non-Western societies gives extra points to proposals that look beyond the West. Yet another panelist ties her opposition to a proposal on Viagra to the fact that she is a lesbian: "I will be very candid here, this is one place where I said, 'OK, in the way that I live my life and my practices' . . . I'm so sick of hearing

about Viagra . . . Just this focus on men, whereas women, you know, birth control is a big problem in our country. So I think that's what made me cranky."²³ Apparently, equating "what looks most like you" with "excellence" is so reflexive as to go unnoticed by some.

The tendency to frame preferences in terms of self-interest may occur in part because it is difficult if not impossible to think of a system of evaluation that would entirely bracket personal tastes. Panelists cannot spell out what defines an "interesting" proposal in the abstract, irrespective of the kinds of problems that captivate them personally. They behave as if they have no alternative but to use their own personal understanding of what constitutes a fascinating problem in order to do the work that is expected of them. After all, their connoisseurship and expertise, which cannot be separated from their ability to judge, is why they were invited to serve.²⁴ And indeed, there is a great deal of uncertainty and unpredictability involved in deliberation. This is why experts who are recognized for their good judgment are needed. Their expertise positions them to demonstrate creativity in situations of improvisation.²⁵

Some disciplines and some scholars may be more open to accommodating personal idiosyncrasies, as we saw in Chapter 3.²⁶ Feminist standpoint theory, for instance, takes an anti-objectivist epistemological stance on the grounds that personal identity influences all aspects of scholarly work.²⁷ But regardless of intellectual position, many panelists are aware of the dangers of rewarding proposals because they aim to do "something very close to what I aspire to do." An anthropologist sums up this customary caution against succumbing to the pull of one's personal interests:

One of the lessons that we learn immediately as anthropologists is, there's a lot of different ways of being in the world. So if you can apply cultural relativism to proposal writing, then you're OK. But you never fully escape from your own interests, your own po-

sition, and so on, and so that is bound to have some impact. I don't know that that's necessarily a bad thing when you have a panel that's sufficiently balanced in all sorts of ways, including academic discipline, areas of expertise, the kind of schools that you come from, and then the obvious, race, ethnicity, and gender. So I do think it is important to bring all of those factors into play in creating the panel, because you aren't going to be able to get rid of those influences.

Promoting Methodological Pluralism

In defining the qualities of a good panelist, respondents, as we saw, put a premium on deferring to colleagues' expertise and sentiments. They also view disciplinary sovereignty as very important. These imperatives point to the value of broad-mindedness and tolerance of differences in evaluation. Panels are not a forum for challenging methodological or disciplinary traditions. The rules of the game require that methodological equality be recognized as a matter of principle. Thus panelists are strongly committed to evaluating proposals according to the epistemological and methodological standards that prevail in the discipline of the applicant—a principle called “cognitive contextualization.”²⁸ This principle is summarized by an evaluator as he describes the dynamics of his panel:

[There are] differences between people who work with large data sets and do quantitative research. And then the very polar opposite, I suppose, folks who are doing community-level studies in anthropology. There are such different methodologies that it's hard to say that there's a generalizable standard that applies to both of them. We were all, I think, willing and able to understand the projects in their own terms, fortunately, and not try to impose a more general standard, because it would have been extremely

difficult . . . I wouldn't hold a candidate in political science responsible for what seemed to me to be having overly instrumental or diagrammatic ways of understanding what they're going to do, because they have to have those. They have to have a certain scientism.

The premium put on "cognitive contextualization" acts as a counterweight to idiosyncratic tastes and pushes panelists to assess proposals through the lenses that are distinctive to the applicant's field. A political scientist makes this clear as he explains how other panel members misunderstood his evaluative criteria:

I was basically being accused of being a positivist. No one ever said that, because obviously that's like calling somebody communist. But there was a sense in which I was imposing my disciplinary bias inappropriately on another discipline. That's what I was picking up. And my response was "No, I actually am holding [the applicant] to her own standards and I'm not trying to be hegemonic on this."

"Cognitive contextualization" presumes a certain methodological pluralism, that is, the ability to understand that different methods serve different purposes. Panelists act on this understanding, even if it may not seem to be in their interest. For instance, a hermeneutically inclined historian says that he "even liked" the political scientist on his panel and argues that "committee[s] always need one fairly tough-minded, empiricist, scientific, social scientist who can hold up that banner and articulate why his standards . . . are [what] they are." Methodological pluralism produces universalism, thus bolstering the legitimacy of collective evaluations.²⁹ But significantly, such methodological pluralism does not favor the use of consistent criteria across disciplines; instead, different proposals prime eval-

uators to use different standards. This complex, nonlinear method speaks to the pragmatic character of evaluation, which is driven by problem solving and satisficing (settling for the “best possible” outcome), as opposed to a more rigid cognitive coherence.

When evaluators describe the panelists who in their opinion were the least impressive, they often mention a lack of methodological pluralism. A geographer expresses her frustration with a political scientist who refused to use the most appropriate tools for evaluating a proposal that focused on meaning: “This [proposal] is not about how many people are actually sick in a population, but rather how many are saying they’re sick in a population, which is about discourse. So it’s not going to fit into nice little number crunching. It’s about how people use issues to mobilize protests, and he was not willing to hear that or entertain that, and it made me mad.” Similarly, a historian criticizes another historian for her lack of disciplinary flexibility: “She sort of has this one standard . . . I mean, she always had this one little test that she seems to be applying to everything. That just seemed to me to be not the most productive way.” Others stress pluralism when describing the panelists they valued most. A historian who also appreciates creativity and “solid” work says, “When I’m trying to judge quality . . . I want to make decisions . . . [that allow] for the maximum diversified ecosystem, you know, the most [different] models of doing work possible.” Another panelist, a political scientist, supports a proposal inspired by rational choice although he is very critical of the paradigm:

Because I am just a wonderfully secular individual, I evaluate [proposals] on their own terms . . . This guy was clearly so smart that if he wanted to do this, he should be allowed to do it. He knew what he was trying to do, he was likely to be influential with folks working in his wing of political science, and it should have been supported. It just seemed to me crazy, unethical virtually,

not to support this proposal, even though you don't agree with it methodologically.

Finally, comparing two years of service on a panel, another historian lauds an "appreciative form of generosity towards what is good work in multiple traditions" among his colleagues the second year. That group embraced "more a kind of imaginative projection into work that is in a very different tradition than your own, you know, that is good work in its own terms. And it seemed to me everybody was to varying degrees committed to doing that." These quotes illustrate clearly how methodological pluralism is essential to the smooth functioning of funding panels.

Setting Aside Disciplinary Prejudices

The customary rules of methodological pluralism, disciplinary sovereignty, and respect for others' expertise and sentiments lead panelists to try to keep their disciplinary prejudices in check. A historian who chaired a panel describes the effort to manage disciplinary prejudices this way: "I think people try to be polite to other disciplines . . . You're not going to say things that other people might find offensive because you're not going to win any points by doing that. And most of the people who are on the committee are the type of intellectuals who realize that almost every tradition, almost every genre, has poor and excellent practitioners." A sociologist, summarizing the "give and take" that characterizes discussions, makes the point that feelings of proximity to or distance from other disciplines and types of scholarship are deliberately muted:

Say it's an identity proposal, and I give it a low score because it doesn't stand up to the sort of criteria that I've laid out, but somebody else gives it a high score . . . The typical pattern in these

meetings is for the low score to listen very carefully to what the higher scores are saying, particularly if the higher scores are from areas where they have certain expertise . . . So there's a certain give and take and compromise, which is quite nice.

This same sociologist recounts how he manages his own disciplinary prejudices:

As I was scoring these proposals, I started to be suspicious that I was giving lower scores to anthropology and history proposals than [those] from the other social sciences—in part because the criteria that I think are important are somewhat discipline-specific . . . It wasn't extreme, but it was there; you could see it in the confusion of scores [I assigned]. And so, when we met, I just 'fessed up. I said, "You know, I think I have a bias in terms of scoring lower for anthropology and history" . . . This particular panel, for whatever reason, could be just the luck of the draw, seems very open-minded and willing to accept the possibility that we each have our particular disciplinary process we use.

A historian tries to offset his biases by "giv[ing] disciplines very far from me the benefit of the doubt," and by being "a little bit harder on ones in my own discipline going in . . . a plus or minus easier or harder because I just don't want to just be bowing to people in American history one hundred percent of the time." This honorable attitude, which requires that scholars voluntarily hold themselves to the highest standards, is essential to the collective belief that the process is fair.³⁰

The tendency to be "a little bit harder" on proposals from one's own discipline varies considerably, however. The historian quoted earlier also acknowledges that not "bowing to" his own field is "a luxury I can afford" because "history does very well" in funding competitions. Philosophers, classicists, and art historians, whose dis-

ciplines garner awards much less frequently—in part because these are small fields that generate far fewer applicants—may feel less magnanimous. Two philosophers were described by their fellow panelists as very eager to see their discipline represented on the lists of awardees. An inverse relationship between generosity toward other disciplines and scarcity may contribute to important differences in the degree to which members of different disciplines engage in disinterested behavior.³¹

Some panelists point out that favoring one's own discipline can be the unintentional result of knowing much more about that field and thus being better able to form an opinion. A musicologist, though, echoing the panel chair quoted earlier who noted that "people tend to be really tough on their [own] discipline," recalls that on her panel, "people cast a particularly critical eye on work from their own field, in part because they knew the field and could evaluate the claims more effectively than a non-specialist." Regardless of the motive for favoring one's discipline, doing so can have significant negative consequences. Panelists often lose credibility by pushing their own fields. A historian of France describes the panelist he liked least as someone who is "very interested in pushing her own field and is not as open to other fields. As she said herself, she's pushing time periods, you know, she'll sponsor anything in the Middle Ages, that kind of thing." Being able to sway colleagues' opinion and gain support for a proposal depends on the overall amount of credibility that one has accumulated. Respecting all the customary rules increases one's credibility with colleagues, in addition to promoting conditions for fair decision making.

The Limits of Legitimacy: Violating the Rules

The taken-for-granted character of customary rules is evidenced when these rules are perceived as being broken, or when they are moot.³² Three of the twelve panels studied experienced disagreements im-

portant enough to require that program officers and some panelists repair relationships among evaluators.³³ Members of these panels recall them as “disappointing” and “nerve-racking,” or as “a panel that turned into a two-day faculty meeting, which is not my idea of fun.” Evaluators are particularly sensitive to the need to respect rules that pertain to collegiality, the use of consistent standards, and the exclusion of academic gossip from the deliberations.

Conflicts and collegiality. Across all panels, breaches of the rules of deference to expertise and respect of disciplinary sovereignty are the most frequent source of conflict and the most common threat to the maintenance of collegiality. Failure to defer can be deeply troubling to academics because so much of their self-identity is tied to their role as privileged expert. An anthropologist admits deliberately withholding deference in the case of a “controversial” co-panelist when that panelist “was, I thought, stepping outside of his field and into mine.” Conflicts may also occur when a panelist is viewed as not upholding reasonable standards, despite having the relevant expertise. A historian explains how an art historian

got noplacé trying to sell [one of the proposals] to the rest of us. This proposal was just not put together very carefully, and she tried to argue that this is really a good person and that even if the proposal wasn’t put together perfectly, [we should] think about it . . . you can throw your expertise out, but you do wind up having to convince at least two other people.

Other panelists say that they refuse to defer to narrow expertise (“I don’t bow to the white lab coat”). When a specialist focuses too closely on detailed considerations that go beyond the general quality of the proposal, other panelists may withhold deference because the expert’s opinions make it more, not less, difficult to differentiate

what is important from what is obscure. The rule of deference is also voided when more than one person claims expertise.³⁴ As we will see in Chapter 6, this situation creates a challenge for the evaluation of truly interdisciplinary proposals, where multiple panelists can legitimately claim relevant expertise.

As noted earlier, respecting other panelists' opinions is an essential quality of a good panelist. Being respectful upholds the customary rule of collegiality. The comments of an anthropologist reveal the resentment that violations of this rule can generate. Describing a conflict over whether some proposals were eligible, he explains:

I had a disagreement [with another panelist] near the start . . . I was a little taken aback because his response to me on that was very direct and kind of in your face. I found it . . . offensive is a little too strong, but I thought it was inappropriate, I guess. It came at a time very early in the panel where everybody's still sort of feeling one another out. It made me a bit uncomfortable.

Breaches of collegiality can go beyond creating discomfort. They can result in open conflict, as the following description of a panelist who was unable to convince others to fund a proposal in his own field shows:

He ate by himself, as we broke after that [discussion] . . . He was extraordinarily upset. It took until pretty close to the end of the meeting for him to . . . get back into the swing of things . . . This was his top proposal that I recall, and so he had a huge stake in this. He couldn't get anywhere with any other members of the committee . . . He did not hear the criticisms that we were offering and they were quite substantive and detailed . . . There was a kind of an undertone that [he thought] we really weren't up to his speed on this.

Such conflicts have to be managed with great care, to ensure that collaboration remains possible until the collective task of the panel has been completed. To this end, program officers, panel chairs, and some panelists engage in “emotion work,” helping their colleagues save face even after defeat and reintegrating them into the group.

When collegiality is low, the panel is considered “bad” or “polluted,” because tension-ridden interactions among panelists undermine the group’s ability to reach consensus regarding the worthiness of proposals. In describing why his panel did not function well, a historian explains:

[Normally], if people have the outlying score, unless it is on a point of unbelievably crucial principle, they just sort of back off after making their case. [But in this case, m]ost of the people really dug in their heels . . . it was strange that people weren’t quicker to get out of the way when they were the only person with a negative opinion . . . Some of it is precedent. If the first five or six that you discuss happen by accident to be ones where there really is a matter of principle at stake that the person objects to, then in a way it forms a model of how you talk about others. There were people enforcing a strong methodological vision, or a strong vision of what constituted quality . . . So they weren’t backing off in a hurry on things.

In this context, a muted expression of enthusiasm can signal disapproval, and any more damning criticisms may be made allusively. Frowning, rolling one’s eyes, sighing, blushing, and talking through clenched teeth are certainly actions that can be as powerful as words. And objections that are not fully articulated dampen debate because they are not amenable to contestation. Fortunately, such behaviors are much more easily controlled in the context of a two-day panel than they can be in, say, departmental deliberations, which occur regularly, have a history, and can be shaped by folk stories about

past conflicts, interpersonal hatreds, and the like. Arguably, in comparison to other contexts of evaluation, it is on grant peer review panels that evaluators exhibit their best behavior and are most inclined to be generous, in part because the decisions made will have very little effect on their own working conditions and daily environment. Thus, panelists often report that they find colleagues from other universities more gregarious than their own immediate colleagues—a reaction common, as well, among academics who share a sabbatical year at a research institute.

Inconsistent criteria. Maintaining consistent criteria for judging qualitative and quantitative proposals is crucial to panel legitimacy, given that tensions between the two types of methods are found in several social science disciplines, and that explanation and interpretation, and positivism and hermeneutics, are fault lines separating the social sciences from the humanities. A political scientist who says he tries very hard “to judge the proposals on their own turf,” also emphasizes,

I try to be consistent in asking the same kinds of questions whether it was somebody who’s going to build a formal model about corruption in Russia, or somebody who was going to access how changes in international legal standing . . . [modify] the perception [of corruption] . . . What I look for, first, is a research design that’s fairly explicit about the nature of the kinds of calls and claims that are being made . . . I want to know the exact relationships they’re trying to map out. I want to know something about the alternative explanations, which ones are being considered, which ones have already been rejected.

Consistency is complicated by the mechanics of deliberation. Panelists compare different subsets of proposals (defined by shared topics, comparable relative ranking, or proximity in the alphabet) at dif-

ferent times. The characteristics that are shared by any one batch of proposals vary and may make different criteria of evaluation more salient. As a historian of China points out:

It does sometimes happen that we get some that are very close to each other, and I always go back again and look at the ones that I thought were really the best and really the worst and see if they're really all that much different. It's like working yourself through any batch of applications or papers or whatever: your standards kind of evolve as you go through it. I don't sort mechanically . . . Until I've read the whole batch, I don't even know exactly what the standards are going to be.

Maintaining consistency is also often at odds with the imperative of cognitive contextualism discussed earlier, which requires that the most appropriate disciplinary criteria be applied. A sociologist, reflecting on the challenge of consistency in criteria, observes:

We were taking different disciplines and trying to make the rules up as we went along, really. We were saying, well, what counts as ethnography in sociology isn't what counts for ethnography in anthropology. It was quite hard, really . . . to remain consistent given that everybody had different consistencies, you know, we were all trying to be consistent in our own ways.

To respect "cognitive contextualization" means to adopt different criteria of evaluation for different proposals. But the resulting incommensurability is very much at odds with a social science epistemology that would suggest that the same standards (about falsification, for instance) should apply to all types of research.³⁵

The application of consistent criteria generated one of the three serious conflicts that emerged on the panels I studied. A scholar de-

scribes a proposal that some thought was methodologically unsophisticated, yet that also seemed somehow grand and highly ambitious. The “fight,” he explains, turned on whether the topic was sufficiently enticing to overcome the proposal’s many other flaws.

It was an absolutely wonderful idea and the people who liked it, at least some of them, were swayed by the idea . . . But when you applied the criteria we often use for proposals to this one, it failed, and it failed miserably. The fight was about do we overlook these criteria or not because we like the topic so much. I couldn’t help but think there was, like, some sets of extrinsic things going on too, like personalities, and there was a political, or ideological [dimension] . . . This applicant . . . was a kind of anti-globalization lefty who was pretty naive about testing, assuming those assumptions are true and then running with them in the proposal as opposed to trying to defend any of them . . . His supporters would go, “This is a cultural history, and that’s really interesting, so . . .” But the proposal actually says, “I’m going to do a social and economic history . . . and *test* whether or not it supported America’s hegemonic ambition.” So [the economist] quite rightly said, “Well, I don’t think he has a clue about how to go about doing that” . . . [Proposals often] fail on those grounds . . . a person states he’s going to do something and you take it on face value. The supporters were going, “Well, no, he didn’t really mean that,” and [it] seemed to me, you can’t really [do that].

Although the proposal was not funded, this panelist voices his concern that standard rules were not applied during deliberation. Later in the interview, he hints at a possible failure in the legitimacy of the decision process when he wonders whether the panel chair had some reason for wanting the project funded. Another panelist, on a different panel, shares a similar concern over legitimacy. He

feels his panel was biased in favor of more humanistic social sciences, so that a proposal with a multi-causal model was penalized. Familiarity with languages also was favored, which meant that anthropologists were more likely to be funded than political scientists. Here again, the legitimacy of the deliberation process may depend on achieving a proper balance between “cognitive contextualization” and consistency, while also avoiding biases.

Two of the panelists most insistent about the use of consistent criteria are highly successful African-American scholars. Their own experience with biases and with being stereotyped and underestimated by professors and colleagues due to their race is likely to have made them particularly sensitive to the application of consistent criteria.³⁶ One, a senior scholar in his sixties, observes that considerations such as whether a proposed project seems to be already completed, or whether the candidate has already received several fellowships, were raised as objections for some cases, but not for other equally problematic cases. And indeed, my observation of panels suggests that all criteria do not remain equally salient from one proposal to the next; the saliency of criteria varies in part with what the proposal evokes in evaluators and how it primes (or prepares) them to frame their own further thinking about the issue.³⁷

Gossip. For some respondents, disciplinary gossip and other extraneous factors have no place in deliberations. This position is illustrated by a younger, female African-American panelist who is adamant that panelists should consider only the evidence in the dossier. She recommends that all panel members be urged explicitly “to make their decision on the basis of the materials before them as opposed to going beyond that.” She expresses her dismay over the fairly low ranking a proposal by a prolific and well-known scholar received prior to deliberations. She attributes this ranking to widely shared negative views about the applicant’s reputation that she, the panelist,

was not privy to. She finds it disturbing that other panelists were reluctant to take a further look at the proposal, and that they seemed to take for granted that it should not be funded. Reflecting on this episode, she describes how the norms of collegiality limit what can be said in the context of panel deliberations:

The one thing that I could not do is what I wanted to do . . . [that] is, to just challenge [them] . . . But having just met all four of these people for the first time, I didn't want to question their integrity. So I [made what] I thought was a somewhat eloquent appeal based on the standard kinds of rationales . . . I admitted maybe I had been duped and all of you have seen through this hoax that he's trying to pull on us, but I saw this as a very interesting theme. And they admitted that, but they said, "It's a cliché."

In reference to an allusion made by a panelist that the applicant was able to secure large advances from publishers, she adds:

That kind of innuendo I thought was unfair. They know about the proposal and what's going on sort of behind the scenes and so on, but they didn't even want to discuss [the proposal]. We never even discussed it, and I didn't push it. First of all, I didn't want to say, "Look, I'm the only [person in the applicant's field] here and although this is treading on everybody's turf, it seems like to me you should [have] at least, you know, talk[ed] about this for five minutes."

Nevertheless, this scholar is satisfied with the competition's overall outcome. She concludes, pragmatically, that "nothing is perfect," and that "human beings will find ways to bend rules, so the only thing that can really help is just to try to get people to have high-level integrity and a sense of fairness."

Extraneous Influences on Panel Outcomes

An array of other factors not directly related to the content of proposals can influence funding decisions. These extraneous factors may be categorized broadly as involving uneven personal influence and power dynamics among panel members (including the effects of racial identity, seniority, and gender); preexisting networks and reputation; and chance. All potentially affect the fairness and legitimacy of a panel's decisions, as well as the credibility that panelists vest in individual panel members.

The effects of uneven personal influence and power dynamics. Beyond the influence of race, seniority, and gender (discussed later), individual panelists' perceived levels of authority can influence outcomes. A pecking order emerges within the group during the process of deliberating. Although this hierarchy remains implicit, it manifests itself concretely. Panelists listen to some members more frequently than others and are swayed more by the opinions of certain members. Many of the conflicts that surround expectations about deference are triggered by perceived slights or challenges to positions in a pecking order. The questions a historian poses as a way to assess panel dynamics capture many of the ways in which personal influence can shape group evaluations: "Did anybody dominate the [deliberations]? Did everyone have a chance to express [themselves]? Was there any scholarly point of view that really didn't get a hearing? Were there times when people felt that their own academic field or standards or values were being challenged indirectly? Directly?" As these questions suggest, differences in degrees of influence across panel members and the power dynamics associated with these differences can affect whether a proposal receives a full hearing.

Panels provide academics with a context for measuring themselves against colleagues. Thus, an individual's panel performance—

as measured by, for example, how successfully she is able to champion a particular proposal—is important to each evaluator’s self-identity.³⁸ Not surprisingly, then, when asked how they thought a meeting went, many panelists spontaneously discuss how much they believe they influenced others versus how much they were influenced by others. Similarly, when asked their opinion about other panelists, interviewees often compare degrees of influence. For instance, one woman, describing a co-panelist she thought made inconsistent judgments, said: “He often seemed to make arguments that no one else would pick up on, and that often seemed irrelevant.”

One of the prime determinants of influence is institutional affiliation. Ivy Leaguers often are perceived as favoring criteria related to who studied with whom and where. And some Ivy League faculty members define themselves, and are defined by others, as undisputed authorities. A panel member from a southern college recalls the patronizing tone of a co-panelist from an Ivy League school when he, the southerner, presented his assessment of a proposal they both were competent to judge. The southerner remembers being surprised by this tone because he had more detailed empirical knowledge of the proposal’s topic than did his co-panelist. Nevertheless, rather than challenging this panelist, he decided that the Ivy Leaguer simply was “used to being an authority.”

A second factor affecting pecking order is personality. In one panel, an anthropologist was singled out as having a particularly strong effect on deliberation outcomes. A sociologist explains this panelist’s influence by noting that “within anthropology anyway, there are so many different approaches” that “inevitably, these things often come down to strong characters who have very specific agendas.” Of the same anthropologist, an art historian says, “In terms of the dynamics, he had a lot of power . . . If he decided he didn’t like something, he would just simply say, ‘Well, that work’s all been done,’ and he would list the literature and then everyone was silent. So he did have

a very powerful influence.” Aggressiveness, stubbornness, and determination can be a potent combination, quite apart from how knowledgeable or well-prepared a panelist may be. “In some cases [funding] really depends on an individual hold-out. If that person didn’t hold out, [a proposal could] get funded,” a sociologist attests.

Some evaluators downplay power dynamics, framing the role of all panel members as consultative. An economist comments: “I didn’t feel like it was gladiatorial combat. I wasn’t there to fight to the death for my proposal . . . I was there to try to give input on stuff that was closest to what I’m knowledgeable on.” He adds, “It’s not like Capitol Hill [where you have to] bring home the bacon for your constituents.” For others, though, posturing is a useful way to make the pecking order visible. Panelists who extensively trash proposals that they know others like sometimes do so in order to flex their muscles and openly assert their position in the pecking order of the panel. While some view this behavior as wholly inappropriate, a political scientist recognizes that other panelists often “get interested in the games that are played around these things,” as though they were watching power matches and following who makes points.

Of course, characteristics such as racial identity, seniority, and gender strongly facilitate or hinder the accumulation of influence, independent of personality and motivation. Social psychologists have shown that people have clear expectations about the kinds of performance and contributions that members of different gender and racial identities will offer to a group. Low expectations for blacks and women are typical.³⁹ This certainly may affect how academics approach the experience of serving on panels.

I did not find any specific instances where the racial identity of panelists directly affected their influence on deliberations. The absence of data on the topic is hardly surprising given the very few people of color who were involved in the panels I studied. Moreover, those panelists may have been reluctant to mention experiences of

stereotyping on panels to a white interviewer, especially since, as was true of most respondents, they did not know of my academic interests in comparative anti-racism. The same can be said about the marginalization that panelists may have experienced due to their lack of seniority. Nevertheless, the social psychology literature gives us good reason to anticipate that both race and seniority affect how much influence panelists exercise and the extent to which they are the object of low expectations.⁴⁰

In contrast, a few interviewees did mention the effect of gender on panelists' level of influence. One woman scholar, an inexperienced panelist, relates the advice she received from another, more experienced panel member:

She said to me afterwards that the gender dynamic often in these meetings can be difficult. She said, "You have to learn how to use language in a way that is almost like a form of warfare, rather than get at the issues. There is a drama to attack that has nothing to do with talking specifically about the projects, but it's how you launch yourself." She said I was just too nice . . . Ultimately my take on it is . . . really this whole committee meeting was a kind of performance. You have to learn to perform in a more bombastic manner to get your points across, and this has nothing to do with really what you say, but how you say it . . . [Another woman] said the same. She said, "You have to do things with a flourish and a dramatic sort of [style]" . . . She said, "You're altogether too nice and diplomatic about it."

Other respondents also referred to gendered patterns of interaction and self-presentation among panelists. For instance, a woman says about another panelist, "He's very bright and was in a performance mode, like a lot of males get into, you know, they're like bred for it, I swear, in academia . . . They need more women next year, to

tone the testosterone down. Seriously, the year before this was not . . . [like that].” Of the other women panelists, she notes, “We tend to defer a little and maybe not be as assertive as perhaps we’d like to be. When I get . . . in a situation with a hard-hitting male, I just want to not say anything. It’s like, ‘I’m not playing this game.’ I don’t want to perform, I just want to do my thing and try to do as good a job as I can.”

A final determinant of personal influence is whether a panelist is perceived by others as having similar standards. This is suggested by a history professor who explains how her appreciation of a co-panelist was rooted in shared theoretical frameworks:

There were just a couple of cases where she and I agreed and we together disagreed with others, and I remember feeling pleased about that, although I really felt quite at peace and attuned to the whole panel. I felt that we understood each other quite well . . . She and I share a post-structuralist intellectual background and perhaps for that reason we share a liking for those projects that took problems that had previously been considered in a binary framework and did something creative with that . . . She has a way of framing problems [using] very broad terms that are not just drawn from her field. I mean, she really reaches out to the humanities for philosophy and all kinds of frameworks that were familiar to me. So I had a good appreciation of her knowledge base and her approach to things. In some respects, that made the conversation much better because I knew where she was coming from . . . When I saw that she had given a proposal a high mark, it encouraged me to spend some time explaining why I thought it was really good.

This panelist’s admission that her co-panelist’s high opinion of a particular proposal “encouraged me to spend some time explaining

why I thought it was really good” might be interpreted by outsiders as an example of personal influence violating the norms of fairness. But evaluators can legitimately use intellectual similarity as a criterion for determining the quality of mind and the level of influence that they are willing to accord fellow panelists.

The effects of preexisting networks and reputation. It seems intuitive that panel deliberations would be affected by personal connections among panelists and by the amount of information they have about one another prior to the deliberations. Indeed, as the comments of the panelist just quoted show, extraneous connections may influence how much weight panelists give to their peers’ opinions.

In most of the cases I studied, however, panelists had no common personal ties and in fact had very little or no information about each other prior to the meetings. (Panelists of the Society of Fellows are an exception, since they all are drawn from a single institution; and in some other cases, evaluators knew one another from having served together on panels in previous years.) That all but a few had no preexisting connections is not surprising, given the size of the American academic community and that program officers for multidisciplinary competitions explicitly aim for diversity, constructing panels that include scholars from various disciplines, regions, and types of universities.

Some evaluators were familiar with the reputation or writings of colleagues in their own or a closely related field before meeting them; some others were connected indirectly, through mutual friends or colleagues. Indirect relationships were more frequent among those living in large metropolitan areas that include many colleges and universities, and among individuals teaching in elite institutions that often sustain dense cross-institutional networks. In one case, two panelists were former colleagues and knew each other very well. In another case, two panelists were involved in overlapping professional

circles. As one panelist, a historian, explains, such familiarity can be welcome:

The person that I felt closest to was the person I knew in advance, someone whom I didn't have to become acquainted with. I can't at all claim that we [are] close friends, but we've had an occasional dinner and we've been at a couple of conferences together, and I knew coming in that it would be relatively easy for us to discuss these issues.

Few evaluators took time to gather information on others prior to the meeting, even though the Internet makes data-gathering easy. For instance, a historian says: "In most cases, I knew the name by reputation. I had never met the anthropologist before last year, but I knew his work. And I think both years I didn't know the economist, and I didn't research. Interestingly, both of them were locals." This paucity of information about academic achievements or personal reputation makes it more likely that candidates will rely on preconceived notions about disciplinary differences as they prepare arguments for and against proposals in response to anticipated objections. The English professor quoted earlier, for example, shaped her defense of a psychoanalysis-inflected proposal based on what she assumed would be her co-panelists' negative reactions to the applicant's "mannered," nonacademic, and potentially "annoying" prose style, based solely on their academic disciplines. The dearth of information on others may also push panelists to be conservative in criticizing what they consider the foibles of other disciplines. Under conditions of uncertainty, it may be safer to err on the side of prudence and excessive collegiality, in order to avoid antagonizing the allies one might need later to label a proposal as a contender (or noncontender).

Chance. Although panelists view their deliberations as legitimate and fair, they also acknowledge an element of randomness in the outcomes. For instance, an English professor says, “Every panel kind of gets its own rhythm going and there is a kind of randomness having to do with who got picked to be on the panel, and the results could be very different on another day . . . I guess I hoped that all of these people are applying to lots of different fellowships and the cards will fall a different way for different people.” She does not describe the process as unfair, but neither does she see it as fully controlled by the participants. This same panelist also notes that judging academic excellence can be a frustratingly inexact undertaking:

I don’t put a huge amount of faith in my or anybody else’s ability to measure it [excellence] exactly. [Just because of] all the subjectivity involved, [there are] field-by-field and even day-by-day or minute-by-minute variations in what might count as excellence for any given person or group of people. Certainly, so much is involved in writing a proposal that has to do with cleverness, and that could be totally different from the excellence of the end result. Things like that, I guess, . . . make me uncomfortable.

Other panelists also readily admit the limitations of panels. An art historian explains that because one cannot predict the composition of the committee, “It is a tremendous game of chance that you can manage to get something funded. That was my sense, that it’s a real crap shoot of who will get the funding and who won’t.” A historian maintains that the best projects do get rewarded, but “with mistakes” because there is “bad judgment, dominating personalities and the review [is done by] people who don’t see the true beauty of some project over another. Mistakes are made. You’re reading a lot of these things in between doing everything else.”

For an English professor, these elements of chance work against the more innovative proposals:

The alternates, sometimes to me they're the ones you really like to see sort of get in because they're just quirky enough, they're just odd enough, and they're just daring enough that they really might come to something so unexpected and unusual and provocative. But those are the ones that really are subject to these other variables, such as: What are the interactions among the members of the committee? Where are the proposals alphabetically? Or in terms of [the order in which they] are being decided? So it's by no means an objective process.

For a historian, luck is especially important in discussions of the more creative proposals, for which usual standards do not apply and which require collective risk-taking: "We have to make decisions that are based on these intangibles about creativity and pushing the envelope, and those are harder, more intuitive, as you probably noticed. You can't say this person's grades are higher or their letters are better; you can't use those criteria."

The sequence and time at which proposals are discussed are also crucial. At the end of the day, people are more pressed, eager to go home, and more disposed, of necessity, to negotiate and reach quicker judgments on each proposal under consideration. In addition, the more contentious proposals often are discussed at the end, after all the easier cases have been dealt with. A political scientist describes the context that emerges at this final stage:

This is one of the last proposals we talked about, one of the very last. At that point we knew we had many grants to give away, and we also knew that we were at number twenty-four or twenty-five,

and we had like three or four proposals to go. [Some] were sort of on the fence, [and] there were a few people who were pushing hard. At this point there was no displacement effect because you knew that if you funded this person, it wasn't going to displace somebody else who might have more [merit]. And so I think they might have just simply said, "Look, you know, it's four-thirty on Saturday. We're at the end of the day. I'm tired. You feel passionate. I don't really care." I don't think [the last award] was [made] on the merit.

Timing and sequence are crucial because each award is made without knowing for sure that there aren't other, more deserving, applications farther down in the pile. Reconsideration at the end is always a possibility, but it is somewhat unlikely given that it requires the energy-consuming challenge of refocusing the panelists' attention on the specifics of a particular proposal. As one anthropologist explained: "I feel that if the meeting had gone another day, and if we had been allowed to pull people out of the 'yes' list and change our minds, there might have been six or seven or eight switches."

Panelists' intellectual exhaustion after two days of intense work also affects how they carry out their task, especially near the end. In particular, during the two days they spend together, panelists often develop a common sense of humor, a group culture of sorts, which may disrupt the seriousness of the deliberations. An art historian observes, "I think as people get more and more tired, certain topics that emerged, people made fun of and became sort of the butt of the joke right through to the very end."⁴¹ Interestingly, because of time pressures (panelists had flights to catch), one of the panels I studied did not distribute all the fellowships it had at its disposal. This is a strong reminder that despite its many otherworldly aspects, judging academic excellence is a process shaped by real-world constraints.

Conclusion

Scholars engaged in grant peer review claim to pursue and honor excellence, and indeed excellence is what holds the academic enterprise together, if not consistently then at least some of the time. The sense of fairness in the pursuit of this objective is maintained by the technology of peer review and by the customary rules described here. Following the rules, which are sometimes revealed most fully when breached, discourages corruption and thus helps ensure that the best proposals are identified.

This chapter has focused on the conventional (that is, widely agreed on) supra-individual rules. Following these rules influences the likely success of arguments—how they will be heard—at least as much as their content (the focus of Chapter 5). The world I described is not one where elites from different evaluative regimes mutually bless one another, nor is it one where narrow social networks coordinate their efforts to engage in opportunity hoarding.⁴² I do not deny that such logics of action are present in academia, but my analysis has revealed that it is not all there is—and it may not be the main thing there is. Breaching some of these rules (the rule about bracketing self-interest, for instance) offends panelists' sense of how things are and should be. Other rules have more to do with the emotional management of panels and are oriented toward ensuring that the process works and that the self-concept of panelists is not violated (the rule about respecting disciplinary sovereignty is one example). These mandates influence the overall feeling that emanates from panels and help generate an emotional energy that makes the enterprise of peer grant review more “sacred” and legitimate.⁴³

The picture that emerges from this review of the customary rules is that of an imperfect but satisfactory system. Strategic voting, horse-trading, self-interest, and idiosyncratic and inconsistent criteria all are unavoidable parts of the equation. Equally important, panelists'

comments and observations show that the act of evaluating is an eminently interactional and emotional undertaking, rather than a cognitive process corrupted by extra-cognitive factors. More specifically:

- The context of evaluation is crucial.⁴⁴ Proposals are evaluated relationally, in comparison with other proposals. The universe of comparison is not stable, nor are the criteria.
- Panelists support a pragmatic understanding of fairness that is at odds with the ideal of considering only the intrinsic qualities of proposals. Because many of the judgments are relational and conjectural, panelists have to think strategically about what they can realistically accomplish.
- The influence of interpersonal relationships, including clientelism, cannot be totally eliminated from the evaluation process, because scholarly expertise is superimposed onto the social networks of those who produce knowledge, including, in this case, both applicants and evaluators.
- Idiosyncratic evaluations are almost unavoidable, yet they are usually presented in universalistic terms and seamlessly folded into formal criteria of evaluation.
- Respecting the customary rules of deliberations is crucial for accumulating credibility with co-panelists (a necessary condition for making one's label "stick" to a proposal) and for facilitating deliberations.

It should be remembered that belief in the fairness of the process is not shared throughout academia. It is likely that scholars invited to serve on panels have strongly internalized the view that peer review "works." Moreover, it is reasonable to surmise that the more successful the scholar, the more likely he or she is to accept and endorse the sacred values of the group—and further, that panelists are generally very successful, given that program officers consider prestige when

recruiting members. Those who never apply for or receive grants and fellowships may be more likely to believe that the allocation system is particularistic and based on cronyism. Nevertheless, the belief in its legitimacy is strong enough to animate the general process of grant peer review, in the United States at least.

The processes of evaluation documented in this chapter apply to multidisciplinary panels. Unidisciplinary panels follow different rules.⁴⁵ The rule of disciplinary sovereignty, for instance, may not apply, and there may be more competition to appropriate the right to speak on a topic when members all are from the same discipline and know one another, at least by reputation. Moreover, the fact that panelists must convince one another of the value of a proposal certainly contributes to their belief in the legitimacy of the process. In contrast, evaluations of journal submissions are conducted in the privacy of a reviewer's office or home and are not defended publicly. This may leave more room for greater personal arbitrariness.

The analysis in this chapter downplayed the effects of panelists' disciplines and institutional affiliations on how they are heard on panels, that is, how much weight is given to their opinion, who gets the benefit of the doubt, and who defers to whom. It also underemphasized the degree to which the same rules apply whether the knowledge being evaluated is more or less technical. Addressing these issues would require having detailed observational data on pecking orders, and paying attention to differences across panels rather than similarities. Nevertheless, I have provided clear evidence of the importance of both collegiality and respect for customary rules. Future research should detail which rules are most faithfully respected by panelists from various disciplines, and which rules are most respected across all panels, including those for competitions not considered here.